

MiG Alley

The fighting in MiG Alley was a gripping study in contrasting tactics and styles of warfare, allowing a direct comparison not only between two closely matched jet fighters but also between pilots trained in very different traditions.

The great strength of the MiG-15s was their performance at high altitude. Cruising at 48,000ft (14,500m) and at just below Mach 1, the MiG was effectively unreachable by the Sabres. If they stayed at this kind of altitude, as they often did, the Sabres were denied the possibility of combat. When the MiG pilots were more aggressively inclined, a number of them would peel away from their mass formation and dive on the Sabres patrolling far below. They would try to get in a shot at the Americans before pulling back up, using their superior rate of climb to escape pursuit. These tactics were known to the American pilots as “Yo-Yo” or, when the MiGs came out of the sun and climbed back toward it again, as “Zoom and Sun.”

The Sabre pilots had an aircraft that was faster than the MiG in level flight and distinctly more effective at lower altitudes. If they could engage the MiGs in a dogfight they had a high chance of success. One effective tactic was dubbed “Jet Stream.” Sixteen Sabres would enter MiG Alley in flights of four at a few minutes’ interval. If the MiGs could be tempted to dive on one of the flights, the others would converge to counterattack.

The Sabres operated at a significant disadvantage in that they were always far from their bases and even with auxiliary fuel tanks – jettisoned before entering combat – they never had more than 20 minutes in the battle zone. The MiGs mostly remained within a few minutes’ flying time of their bases over the Chinese border. The Sabres were also constantly outnumbered, usually by at least three or four to one. Yet they had by far the better of the fighting. Although estimates vary, it may be that 792 MiGs were destroyed in air combat by Sabres, compared with 78 Sabres shot down by MiGs – a kill ratio of 10 to 1.

The crucial factor was pilot quality. Although the communists deployed some excellent Soviet pilots, these experienced fliers were very much in the minority. Most communist pilots were good at following instructions, but showed little initiative or aggression and often made basic errors in dogfights. The American pilots displayed an outstanding hunger for battle – many had plotted and schemed for months or years to arrange a transfer from some safe posting in the United States or Europe to the Korean front line. They had the “right stuff” in plentiful supply, and this proved decisive.

Mikoyan–Guryevich MiG-15



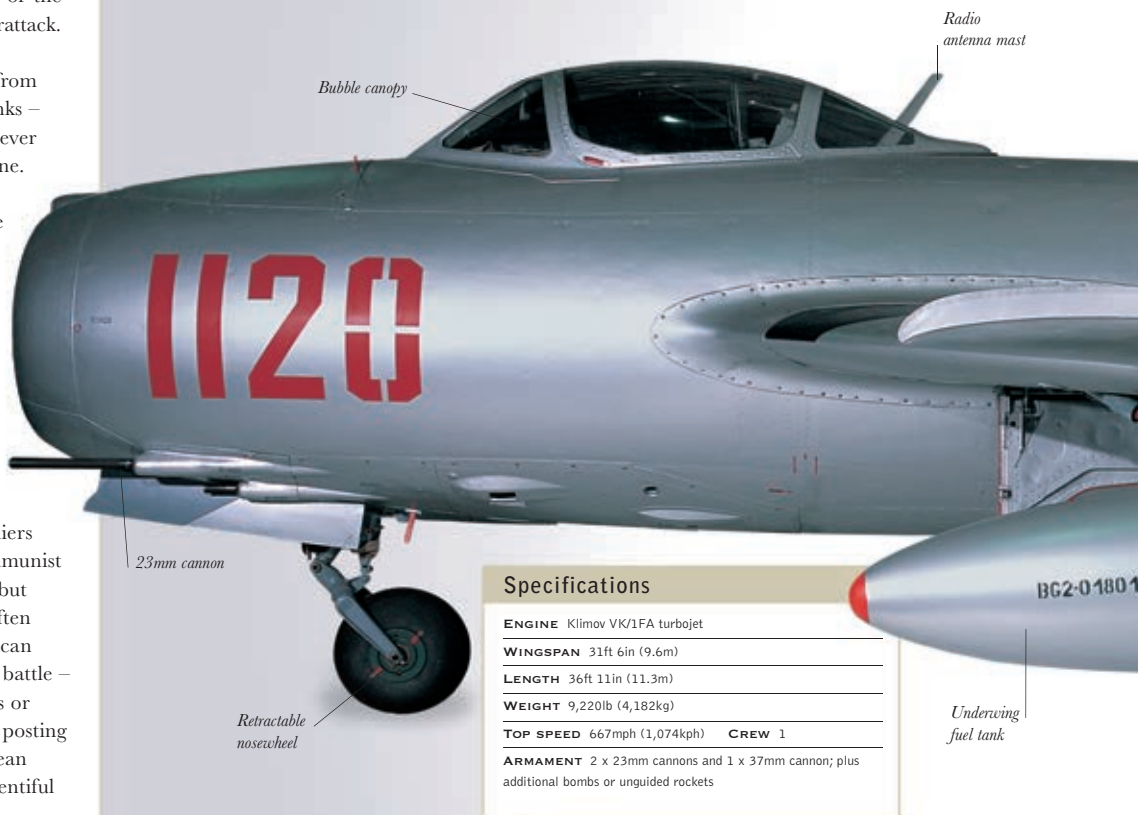
THE MiG-15 WAS A PRODUCT of the Soviet design bureau headed by Artyem Mikoyan and Mikhail Guryevich. The aircraft first flew in December 1947, two months after the maiden flight of the US F-86 Sabre. These two airplanes were destined to be the key players in the battle for air supremacy during the Korean War (1950–3). The Sabre and the MiG-15 were similar in their swept-wing configuration but different in purpose. The Sabre was an air-superiority fighter; the MiG-15 was primarily intended as an interceptor. The MiG-15 was originally produced to protect the Soviet Union from the threat of fleets of American bombers flying into Soviet airspace at high altitude. The designers therefore created an aircraft with a service ceiling of about 51,000ft (15,500m) and a rate of climb of 9,000ft (2,750m)

“It was a beautiful sports car of a fighter... It looked like a first-class airplane.”

LIEUTENANT-COLONEL BRUCE HINTON
FIRST SABRE PILOT TO SHOOT DOWN A MiG-15

per minute. And they armed it with powerful cannons – preferable to machine guns for striking a bomber but less effective in a dogfight.

US pilots in Korea were upset to find that the MiG-15 had an advantage over their Sabres of about 3,000ft (900m) per minute in a climb. Furthermore, the MiG-15s could operate at altitudes that the Sabres simply could not reach. When a North Korean pilot defected with a MiG-15 in 1953, no less a person than Chuck Yeager (the first man to break the sound barrier) was flown out to Japan to look it over. He found nothing revolutionary – just a tough, agile, well-designed aircraft with a suitably powerful engine. Korean War ace Captain James Jabara also felt that the MiG-15 was nothing special, stating: “The F-86 is the best jet fighter in the world and the MiG is the second best.”



Specifications

ENGINE	Klimov VK/1FA turbojet
WINGSPAN	31ft 6in (9.6m)
LENGTH	36ft 11in (11.3m)
WEIGHT	9,220lb (4,182kg)
TOP SPEED	667mph (1,074kph)
CREW	1
ARMAMENT	2 x 23mm cannons and 1 x 37mm cannon; plus additional bombs or unguided rockets

Underwing
fuel tank